### Passing Data to Layouts

Layouts have access to all the same data that's available to conventional templates. In addition, any instance variables set in the normal template will be available in the layout (because the regular template is rendered before the layout is invoked). This might be used to parameterize headings or menus in the layout. For example, the layout might contain this:

```
<html>
  <head>
    <title><%= @title %></title>
    <%= stylesheet_link_tag 'scaffold' %>
  </head>
  <body>
    <h1><%= @title %></h1>
    <%= yield :layout %>
  </body>
</html>
```

An individual template could set the title by assigning to the `@title` variable:

```
<% @title = "My Wonderful Life" %>
<p>
  Dear Diary:
</p>
<p>
  Yesterday I had pizza for dinner. It was nice.
</p>
```

We can take this further. The same mechanism that lets us use `yield :layout` to embed the rendering of a template into the layout also lets you generate arbitrary content in a template, which can then be embedded into any template.

For example, different templates may need to add their own template-specific items to the standard page sidebar. We'll use the `content_for` mechanism in those templates to define content and then use `yield` in the layout to embed this content into the sidebar.